

TaskWA

User Manual

Everything your team needs in two pages — and everything the administrator needs in the rest.

Version 1.7 · July 2026

I For team members — the only pages you need

TaskWA sends you one WhatsApp message each morning with your open tasks. You reply in the same chat. That's the whole system.

Your morning message looks like this:

Good morning, Ravi - 3 open tasks today:

1. [HIGH] Send Q2 invoice to Alpha LLC - due Fri 17 Jul
2. Buy cement for Site B - due today
- [!] 3. Fix generator - BLOCKED 2d: waiting on supplier quote

Reply: 1 done | 1 in progress | 1 block <reason>

Replying — use the number from the list, then the word:

You send	What happens
1 done	Task 1 is closed. You get a thumbs-up reaction as confirmation.
2 in progress	Task 2 is marked started.
3 block waiting on quote	Task 3 is marked blocked with your reason, and the admin is told immediately. Always include the reason.
3 block waiting on @Priya	Same, but the block is handed to Priya: she gets one message telling her you're waiting on her, with instructions to release it.
3 unblock	You release a block that waits on YOU (your part is done, or there is no block on your side). The task flips back to in-progress and its owner is told.
1 reopen	Made a mistake? This reopens a task you closed.
done	If you have only one open task, no number is needed.

Even easier — swipe to reply. Swipe (long-press → Reply) on the task's message and just type **done**. The bot knows which task you mean.

See your list any time: send **/mytasks**. **Confused?** Send **/help**.

See it as a picture — /board

Sometimes a list isn't enough. Send **/board** (or **/myboard**) and TaskWA replies with an image — your own tasks laid out as a board: Blocked, In progress, To do, and what you finished in the last 7 days. It's yours alone; nobody else's tasks appear on it, and nobody else can pull yours except an admin naming you on purpose (next part).

Creating a task

Send **/add** with a title. Mention someone to assign it to them; add **!high** or **!low** for priority; add **#group** to post it to a registered group (any part of the group's name works — **#site** finds 'Site B Construction'; for a space, dot it or quote it — next section); end with a date word — today, tomorrow, fri, or 25/07:

```
/add Send Q2 invoice @Priya fri !high
```

Create task: "Send Q2 invoice" -> Priya,
due Fri 17 Jul, high priority?
Reply Y to confirm, N to cancel.

Reply **y** and it's created. Nothing is created without your confirmation. In a group, the task shows up in that group's daily list; otherwise **the assignee is told immediately** (next section).

Created it with a #group tag? On your Y the bot posts one announcement in that group — "New task for Ravi: ..." with the reply numbers — so you instantly see it reached the right place. You must be a member of that group yourself (admins are exempt); if WhatsApp privacy settings prevent verifying the member list, the task is refused rather than guessed.

Track what you've delegated: send **/myadd** — every open task you created for someone else, with its status, age of any block, and the reminder that you can close or cancel each one.

Names with a space — dot it or quote it

WhatsApp doesn't tell the bot where a typed name ends, so a name with a space needs one of two marks: a **dot in place of the space**, or **quotes around the whole name**. Both work everywhere a name or a group can appear — /add, /nudge, and block waiting on.

You type	Who it means
@Ravi.Shankar	Ravi Shankar. The dot stands for the space — shortest to type, never ambiguous.
@"Ravi Shankar"	The same person, written naturally. Your phone's curly quotes (" ") are understood too — you don't have to fight autocorrect.
@Ravi	Also Ravi Shankar, as long as no one else on the team starts with 'Ravi'. If it's ambiguous the bot says so rather than guessing.
@Ravi Shankar	Understood as well — the bot joins the words back into a name. It works, but the dot or the quotes are the forms that can never be misread.
#site.b · #"Site B" · #Site B	The group 'Site B Construction'. Groups follow exactly the same three rules as names — dot, quotes, or plain spaces — and any unique part of the group's name is enough. If the tag matches two groups the bot asks you to be more specific rather than guessing.

Tapping WhatsApp's own @-mention picker always works as well — the bot resolves the number behind it.

Two people with similar names? The bot asks

If what you typed could mean more than one person, the bot does not guess — **it lists them and asks you to pick a number**. The same happens if you mistype a name (it offers the closest matches), and if a #tag matches two groups.

```
/add Fix the pump @Ravi tomorrow !high
```

'@Ravi' matches 2 people:

1. Ravi Shankar (...0002)
2. Ravi Kumar (...0045)

Reply with the number. Anything else cancels this and is read as a new message.

2

Create task: "Fix the pump" -> Ravi Kumar,
due Wed 15 Jul, high priority?
Reply Y to confirm, N to cancel.

The rest of your message survives the detour — the title, the date and the priority are all carried through, and you carry on with the normal **Y**. The last four digits of each number are shown so you can tell two same-named people apart. **Only a bare number answers the question: 2 done** still means 'task 2 is done', and anything else simply drops the question and is read as a new message.

When a task is created FOR you

The moment someone assigns you a task, you get a message — no waiting for tomorrow's digest:

New task from Sudhakar: Send Q2 invoice,
due Fri 17 Jul

Reply Y to accept, N to decline
(no reply in 30 min counts as accepted).

Reply: 7 done | 7 in progress
| 7 block <reason>

Y accepts. **N** sends the task straight back to whoever created it — it never just disappears. Say nothing for 30 minutes and it counts as accepted. The number in the message (the task's permanent #) works right away.

Created it yourself? The creator keeps two powers over their own task even after it's assigned: **7 done** closes it, **7 cancel <reason>** cancels it — the assignee gets one notice either way. Everything else (starting, blocking) stays with the assignee.

Waiting on a teammate? Hand them the block

Stuck because someone else must act first? Name them with an @ and the bot runs the follow-up for you:

3 block waiting on @Priya

Priya - Ravi is waiting on you for task #3:
Fix generator
Reason: waiting on @Priya

Reply: 3 unblock - when your part is done,
or if there's no block on your side.

Priya's **3 unblock** flips the task back to in-progress and tells Ravi it's on him again. Until then her own morning digest reminds her under **Waiting on you**. She can release the block, but she cannot close Ravi's task.

Good to know: only you (or an admin) can close your tasks — a teammate can't mark your work done. The bot never reads receipts, never replies to normal conversation, and stays completely silent in chats that aren't registered.

II For the administrator

You run TaskWA from the dashboard at `http://localhost:3000` on the machine where it is installed. Log in with the admin password. This part walks the dashboard page by page, then covers troubleshooting and routine care.

The Tasks page — your daily driver

The front page lists tasks with filters for status and assignee (the default view is everything still open). Each row shows the task's permanent # number, blocker details in red, and the group it posts to. Under **Actions**:

Control	What it does
✓ Done / ✗ Cancel	One click closes or cancels the task (Cancel asks for confirmation). The assignee gets one WhatsApp notice that it's off their list — in the task's group if it has one, else a DM. No notice when the assignee is an admin.
Status dropdown + Set	Any other transition — reopen, in progress, blocked (type the reason in the note box first). An impossible change shows a red banner explaining why instead of failing silently.
edit	Expand to change title, assignee, priority, due date, description or group posting.
New task (below the list)	Create a task from the browser — the assignee gets the same instant accept/decline message as with /add.

Exports live at the bottom of the page: **tasks.csv** (current data) and **audit.csv** (every status change ever, with who, when and the raw message text).

Members

Register each person with a name and their WhatsApp number (country code + number, digits only — e.g. 9715xxxxxxx). The number IS their identity: messages from any other number are ignored silently. Roles: **admin** receives blocker alerts and can update anyone's task; **member** manages only their own. Deactivating a member stops their digests and their commands instantly — reassign their open tasks first from the Tasks page. **Change a member's role any time** with the dropdown in their row (it saves on selection). Promotion to admin is deliberately dashboard-only — no chat command can do it — and the last active admin cannot be demoted: promote a successor first.

The fast way — import from a group. Members page → **Import from group** → pick a registered group: every participant appears in a table with their name and number pre-filled. Tick the ones you want, fix names, click Import — done. Participants whose numbers WhatsApp hides (privacy settings) are shown with the remedy: save them as a contact, or make the bot's number a group admin, and re-detect.

Groups

Add the bot's WhatsApp number to the group, then click **Detect my groups** on the Groups page — every group the number belongs to appears with a one-click Register button. Only registered groups are listened to; everything else stays private. Tasks flagged 'post to group' (or created via /add inside the group) appear in that group's daily digest instead of the assignee's personal one.

The Board page — kanban view (new in v1.7)

Dashboard → Board shows every open task as four columns — To do, In progress, Blocked, Done (last 7 days only, so it doesn't grow forever) — with a per-assignee filter. It's read-only: a quick shape-of-the-work view, not a second place to edit tasks. While v1.7 is new, the page carries an amber 'in development' banner as a heads-up that layout may still change.

Preview before anyone sees anything. The same page has a **Preview selected boards** panel — tick any members and/or groups, pick which admin should receive it (if there's more than one admin), click send: the rendered board images go to that admin's own WhatsApp chat only. Nothing goes to the team. Use this to see exactly what a member's board image looks like before turning anything on for real. The same thing is available from WhatsApp as **/board preview @Name** (admin-only, DM-only; no name previews everyone).

Board snapshot — an optional picture on a schedule. Settings can turn on a recurring send of each person's board image, on up to two chosen days a week, at a set time. It ships **off by default** — nothing goes out until you turn it on. There is also a **test mode**: with test mode on, the real schedule fires for real (proving the day/time actually works) but every image is redirected to one admin instead of the team, captioned with who it would really have gone to. The intended order: turn it on with test mode on and a near-term time, confirm the images look right, turn test mode off for exactly one real send to the team as a final check, then set the schedule you actually want and leave test mode off.

Nudger — your own plain messages, on a schedule

The Nudger sends **exactly the text you type** to chosen members and groups — no task numbers, no headers, no reply footer: polite nudging without seeming like an assigned task. Recipients and groups see an ordinary WhatsApp message from you. Use it for the daily good-morning, status follow-ups, or anything that isn't a task. Manage nudges here on the dashboard, or entirely from WhatsApp with **/nudge** (next section).

On the Nudger page	Notes
Message text	Sent verbatim. {date} becomes '11 July 2026', {day} becomes 'Friday'. WhatsApp *bold* and <i>_italic_</i> work.
Days + send time	Tick weekdays and set a time — or leave the time empty for a manual-only nudge you fire with Send now.
Time zone	Each nudge has its own timezone dropdown (defaults to the dashboard setting) and is PINNED to it when saved — changing the dashboard timezone later never moves an existing nudge.
Recipients	Any registered members and groups. To message someone who isn't on the task team, register them as a member — with no tasks they'll never get digests, only your nudges.
Pacing	Recipients are messaged 20–45 seconds apart and never overlap other TaskWA sends — ban-risk hygiene. A missed send (machine off) is deliberately skipped, not delivered late.

Admin commands over WhatsApp — no dashboard needed

Admins can run the essentials from their phone by **DM'ing the bot directly** (on a personal-number install that means your own 'Message Yourself' chat). These commands are ignored in groups and refused for non-admins; anything that creates or deletes asks Y/N first. No AI involved — fixed wording, options first, message last.

Command	What it does
<code>/nudge 07:30 tue @Ravi.Shankar #site What is the status?</code>	Create a nudge: the time is required — without one the bot asks for it rather than creating a nudge that never fires. Write it however you like: 07:30 · 7:30 · 730 · 0730 · 7.30 · 7:30am · 730pm · 7am all mean the same thing. (A bare 3 is read as a nudge <i>number</i> , not 3 o'clock — write 3pm or 15:00.) Then days (or 'daily' / omit = every day), @Name members and #group targets, then the message, sent verbatim. A name with a space is dotted or quoted — @Ravi.Shankar or @"Ravi Shankar". Timezone pins to the dashboard setting. Manual-only nudges (no time) can still be made on the dashboard.
<code>/nudges</code>	Numbered list of every nudge with schedule, recipients and active/paused state.
<code>/nudge 3 08:15 tue,thu</code>	Reschedule nudge 3 — time, days and/or recipients. The text never changes this way: delete and recreate, or use the dashboard.
<code>/nudge off 3 /nudge on 3</code>	Pause / resume instantly (reversible, so no confirmation).
<code>/nudge delete 3</code>	Delete after a Y/N confirmation.
<code>/adduser 971501234567 Ravi Kumar</code>	Register a member (spaces and + in the number are fine). Always role 'member' — promoting to admin stays a dashboard-only act. Re-adding an inactive number reactivates it. CHECK THE NUMBER in the Y/N prompt: a typo would register a stranger.
<code>/rename @Ravi Ravi Shankar</code>	Change the name TaskWA shows for someone — the name the team reads in group announcements ('New task for ...'), digests and blocker alerts. It is not your phone's contact name, and editing it here does not touch your contacts. Y/N confirmed. Two members can never share a name: the name is how people are addressed (@Ravi), so a duplicate would make '@Ravi' ambiguous and work could land on the wrong person — the bot refuses. Same thing inline on the dashboard's Members page.
<code>/members</code>	List everyone registered, with roles and inactive flags.
<code>/board preview @Ravi.Shankar #Site.B</code>	Render the named member(s)/group(s) board(s) and send them to YOUR own WhatsApp only — never the team. Leave off the names to preview everyone at once. Same feature as the dashboard's Preview panel, for when you're on your phone.
<code>/help</code>	Role-aware: members see member commands; admins (in DM) also get this admin section.

Settings that matter

Setting	Meaning
Timezone & send times	IANA timezone (e.g. Asia/Dubai) and one or more daily digest times, comma-separated (08:00, 17:00).
Acknowledgment mode	reaction (thumbs-up on the message — recommended), reply (a text 'Noted.'), or silent.
Personal number mode	ON when the bot shares your own WhatsApp number. The bot then never replies to anything that isn't a command, your private chats are never touched, and your own digest arrives in 'Message Yourself'.

Setting	Meaning
Dry-run	The safety switch: ON means every message is logged on the Health page instead of being sent. Use it whenever you experiment.
Hourly cap / retention	Upper bound on messages per hour (ban-risk hygiene) and days before completed tasks are archived to CSV and purged (default 30).

The Health page — your first stop when anything seems wrong

Status	What to do
WORKING	All good. Check 'last digest' and 'last backup' times occasionally.
SCAN_QR_CODE	WhatsApp logged the number out — only a scan fixes it. Click Re-pair (new QR), scan with the bot number's phone (WhatsApp → Linked devices), refresh.
STARTING	Be patient — 30–60 seconds on Apple Silicon.
FAILED / STOPPED	The engine crashed or stopped, but the pairing is still good. Click Restart gateway session — it restarts the session with no QR. If it keeps failing, restart the container (see Installation Guide, Troubleshooting).
UNREACHABLE	The gateway container isn't running — usually right after a reboot; Docker brings it back on its own within a minute. Persisting: <code>docker compose up -d</code> from the install folder.

The message log at the bottom shows every outbound message with its status — including **dryrun** (not sent, dry-run on), **failed** (gateway error, shown), and **blocked** (recipient not registered — the allowlist refused it, which is the system protecting you).

When the session fails — restart vs re-pair

A failed session is one of two things, and the two Health-page buttons match them. **Most failures are just a crashed engine** — the WhatsApp pairing saved on your disk is still valid, so a plain restart brings it back with no QR. Press **Restart gateway session**; it restarts the session with the pairing intact and fixes most FAILED/STOPPED cases and stuck sends. Recovery is deliberately manual — a click, never automatic — because repeatedly restarting a personal WhatsApp number is itself a ban signal. **The other kind is a real logout** — WhatsApp dropped the linked device (the phone was off for days, or the bot's number was opened in WhatsApp Web/Desktop somewhere else). No restart can fix that; it needs a fresh scan, so use **Re-pair (new QR)** and scan. **The quick tell:** press Restart gateway session and if a QR still appears, it was a real logout — scan it and you're back. Your tasks, history and backups are never touched either way.

If you find yourself re-scanning every few days, the session isn't crashing — it's being logged out, and the usual causes are the phone going offline, the bot's number being open in WhatsApp Web/Desktop on another device, or the machine running low on memory. Keep the phone online and the number off other WhatsApp Web sessions.

Troubleshooting — the restart cookbook

All commands run in Terminal, from the folder TaskWA is installed in (the one containing `docker-compose.yml` and `data/`). Nothing here loses data — the database, backups and the WhatsApp pairing all live in `data/` on your disk and survive every restart below.

Situation	Do this
WhatsApp gateway stuck (FAILED / stuck QR / no messages)	On the Health page click Restart gateway session first — it restarts the session with no QR and fixes most cases. Still stuck: <code>docker compose restart waha</code> — wait a minute, check Health. Stubborn: <code>docker compose up -d --force-recreate waha</code> (pairing survives; a QR afterwards just means it was a real logout — re-scan it).
App misbehaving / dashboard not loading	<code>docker compose restart app</code>
Restart everything cleanly	<code>docker compose down</code> then <code>docker compose up -d</code>
Docker itself is wedged	Quit Docker Desktop from the whale menu, reopen it, wait for the steady whale, then <code>docker compose up -d</code> .
'docker: command not found'	Docker's CLI links are broken (typical after switching container engines). Docker Desktop → Settings → Advanced → toggle the CLI tools to User , Apply, back to System , Apply & Restart (enter your password). Never run two container engines at once.
Nothing starts after a reboot	The autostart isn't armed. From the install folder run <code>./scripts/autostart-macos.sh</code> (Windows: <code>autostart-windows.ps1</code> , Linux: <code>sudo ./scripts/autostart-linux.sh</code>). Also set: Docker Desktop → 'Start when you sign in', automatic login, and on a Mac <code>sudo pmset -a autorestart 1</code> for power cuts. Verify: <code>check launchctl list grep taskwa</code> , log at <code>/tmp/taskwa-autostart.log</code> . Full chain: docs/UNATTENDED.md.
What actually happened?	<code>docker compose logs app --since 30m</code> — every message, drop reason and error is logged. The Health page's message log shows every outbound send and why any were blocked.

The acid test after any repair: reboot the machine, touch nothing, wait three minutes, open the Health page — it should say **WORKING** on its own.

Routine care

- **Backups are automatic** — nightly database snapshots, 14 kept, in the backups folder. To restore: stop the app, copy a snapshot over `data/tasks.db`, start again.
- **Exports** — `tasks.csv` and `audit.csv` from the Tasks page, any time.
- **Forgotten password** — 'Forgot password' on the login page sends a 6-digit code to your WhatsApp. If WhatsApp itself is down: `docker compose exec app python -m app.cli reset-password`
- **Upgrades** — see docs/UPGRADE.md; in short: `git pull`, `docker compose up -d --build`. Data survives.
- **Survive restarts automatically** — run the one-command autostart installer for your OS (`scripts/autostart-macos.sh`, `autostart-windows.ps1`, `sudo autostart-linux.sh`): at every login/boot it starts Docker, waits for the engine, and brings TaskWA up. Full four-link chain (auto power-on, auto-login, Docker, containers) in docs/UNATTENDED.md.
- **Keep the machine awake** — a sleeping laptop sends no digests. Digests missed by under 6 hours send on wake; missed nudges are skipped on purpose.

The one standing risk, stated plainly: TaskWA uses an unofficial WhatsApp gateway. WhatsApp can ban the paired number without notice. Keep volumes modest, keep the hourly cap on, and understand that on a personal number, the ban risk is to your personal account. Your task data is never at risk — only the delivery channel.